

FILM REVIEWS

AJAB PREM KI GHAZAB KAHANI

Charisma Kapoor

RATING ★ ★ ★ ☆ ☆

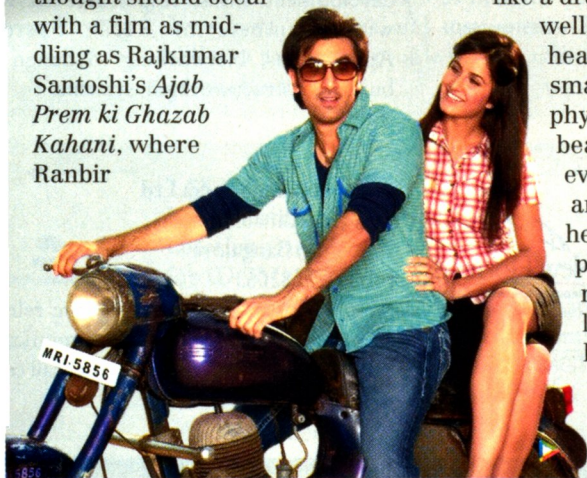
Director: Rajkumar Santoshi

Starring: Ranbir Kapoor, Katrina Kaif

Every generation deserves its own pin-ups. Someone they can hyperventilate about, follow obsessively, and yes, fantasise about. The sturdy Khans have served almost two generations faithfully. Perhaps it's time to move on? It's surprising that the thought should occur with a film as mid-dling as Rajkumar Santoshi's *Ajab Prem ki Ghazab Kahani*, where Ranbir

Kapoor plays a loveable Class IX dropout, a small town loser who runs a Happy Club, hangs about eating free meals at his dad's café, conducts conversations with Jesus Christ, innocently believes in all sorts of stereotypes and spends his time dreaming about the vanilla ice cream girl who's clearly out of reach. He's the epitome of the post-consumerist slacker dude, only he won't know what it means. If Kapoor appealed to south Mumbai with *Wake Up Sid*, where he was the ultimate man child, in *Ajab...* he's going for Meerut. He does everything to please—dances like a dream, plays physical comedy well, and looks adequately bed-headed while romancing every small town boy's ultimate trophy, a fair-skinned, Anglicised beauty, Katrina Kaif. He is everything that middle India is and his only aspiration is that he will do something which will put him on the front page of a newspaper. What's more, he looks pretty in pink too. A knowingly unsophisticated film that sails on its star's natural charisma.

by Kaveree Bamzai



JAIL

Prison Brake

RATING ★ ★ ☆ ☆ ☆

Director: Madhur Bhandarkar

Starring: Neil Nitin Mukesh, Mugdha Godse

Imagine *Bigg Boss* set in a jail, without the expletives. Now think of *Jail*, in what is now becoming a jaded Madhur Bhandarkar formula. He's so far completed several anthropological field trips, from metropolitan high society to the fashion industry. With each film, he has begun to see all sides to a story. Which is good news but bad cinema. Every good policeman is offset by a corrupt official; every thuggish inmate has a foil in the philosopher prisoner; and for every bad lawyer, there's one who saves the day. Add a style that has not evolved much, references to real life characters from Binayak Sen to Alistair Pereira, and you have less of a film and more of a case study. Even the sex and scam seem seriously tedious.

-KB



THEATRE

Act in the PAST

Vaikom Muhammad Basheer is to Malayalam literature what Sadat Hassan Manto is to Urdu and what Munshi Premchand is to Hindi. Basheer's centenary year was celebrated across the state and by people across the world that loved his work. The Perch Foundation, Chennai, was instrumental in producing two plays in English based on the writer's stories. Directed by Rajiv Krishnan, the plays *Moonshine and Skytoffee* and *Sangati Arinhyas*? (Have you heard?) weave together some of his best



SANGATI ARINHYA?

work. *Moonshine...* weaves together two stories while *Sangath...* is a combination of seven. While being dramatised for stage, *Sangati...* and *Moonshine...* have managed to acquire a certain seamlessness as works of theatre experimenting with both form and content. From November 21 to 22 at Kalakshetra and from December 15 to 20 at Prithvi Theatre in Chennai.

by Nirmala Ravindran

IF YOU HAVE 60 MINUTES, see the photographs of the late artist Nicholas Roerich at the M.F. Husain Gallery, Delhi, on till November 17.